



Using automated analysis of the bibliography to detect potential research integrity issues

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Key points:

- Efforts to assess research integrity in scholarly publications tend to focus on the front matter (e.g., fake authors) and the article body (e.g., data falsification, image manipulation, plagiarism).
- Automated analysis of the bibliography may surface fingerprints pointing to research integrity issues.
- Tools exist that can be used at all workflow stages, from manuscript submission through production, to detect citations of retracted articles and articles published by predatory publishers.
- Validation of bibliographic references against trusted databases can be used to help detect fake or chimeric references generated by artificial intelligence applications.

Keywords: AI, automation, research integrity, retractions

INTRODUCTION

Misconduct in scholarly publishing has a long and inglorious past (Lingua, 2000; Khajuria & Agha, 2014). Several measures suggest it is increasing rapidly; for example, Fang et al. (2012) reported a tenfold increase in the number of scientific articles retracted due to fraud since 1975. Pressure to 'publish or perish' increases the potential rewards of subverting the publishing process, and the move to digital publishing has made fraud easier to perpetrate and, arguably, both easier and harder to detect (Barnett, 2023; Brainard, 2023).

Publishers' and readers' efforts to detect issues that undermine research integrity tend to focus on the article body (e.g., image manipulation, data falsification, inappropriate statistical analysis, plagiarism; see, e.g., Eckhardt & Ruxton, 2023) or the front matter (e.g., fake or compromised authorship; see

Oransky, 2019). But another article section can also hold clues to publishing fraud: the bibliography. It is relevant in the 'age of ChatGPT', to note that bibliographies are something large language models (LLMs) currently find difficult to replicate convincingly (Kendrick, 2023). Research interest in this area is growing, and while we were writing this update in late 2023, Walters and Wilder (2023) reported that while 55% of bibliographic references generated by ChatGPT-3.5 in their study were fabricated, the rate fell to 18% with ChatGPT-4. Their analysis required manual verification of 636 references, however, which is clearly not a practical solution for publishers or readers.

While LLMs may well continue to get better at generating appropriate bibliographic reference lists, in the immediate term, there is still a need for methods to detect 'hallucinated' reference lists rapidly and in bulk.

This industry update focuses on automated ways to analyse the bibliography and identify fingerprints that can point to research integrity issues. We will look at three specific factors: citations to retracted items, citations to articles from publishers suspected of predatory or questionable practices, and clues to 'chimeric' or entirely fake references generated by LLMs.

[†]Bruce Rosenblum זיכרוננו לברכה (of blessed memory) passed away on 13 December 2023. This article is dedicated to Bruce's memory, in recognition of his wide-ranging contributions to scholarly publishing, his efforts to promote accessibility in publishing, and his advocacy of ALS research.

DETECTING CITATIONS TO RETRACTED MATERIAL

Faced with what we might call an ongoing retraction tsunami (see Oransky, 2022), some scholarly publishers have developed policies for dealing with citations to retracted material. One organization we work with, a leading publisher of highly cited articles, has adopted the following approach. When a retracted article is detected in the bibliography of a submitted or accepted article, the corresponding author is informed and offered two options: remove the citation and any statements that depend on it alone; or provide a justification for citing the retracted item, acknowledge that it has been retracted both *at the point of citation* and in the bibliography, and modify their conclusions accordingly where appropriate.

But such a policy depends on being able to detect retracted material in the first place. As yet, no industry-wide standards exist for display, notification, or metadata handling of retractions, withdrawals, and other modifications of the publishing record, although the NISO CREC Working Group is currently creating a recommended practice (NISO, 2023). Therefore, detecting a majority of retracted or withdrawn articles requires multiple strategies.

Arguably the most robust approach uses metadata available from trusted services such as PubMed and Crossref. PubMed has a standard method to indicate that an article has been retracted; for articles deposited to Crossref, the Crossmark service (Crossref, 2020) can be used to detect retractions.

Unfortunately, each of these datasets is incomplete. PubMed indexes only a subset of the scientific literature. Many publishers do not report retractions or article status changes to PubMed or Crossref, report only some, or report them incompletely. Not all references have PubMed IDs or DOIs, and not all DOIs are deposited to Crossref; while some are registered with other agencies, such as mERDA or KISTI, we know from reviewing

Retraction Watch (RW) data that predatory publishers sometimes create DOIs but don't register them. The most complete retraction detection requires expanding the search by incorporating multiple databases, because no single database or combination of databases has a completely comprehensive index of retracted literature (Schneider et al., 2023).

Wiley's Edifix service (available at <https://edifix.com>) uses the PubMed, Crossref (Crossmark and updated titles), and RW databases to detect and report on retracted items (Edifix, 2023). For example, an article indexed as retracted by both PubMed and Crossref will return warnings as shown in Fig. 1.

However, not all publishers that deposit to Crossref use Crossmark; some simply update the item metadata at Crossref with a new title to indicate the retraction. Because there are many different ways of updating the title (see appendix A in Uppala et al., 2022), this method of detection is less reliable than standardized Crossmark metadata. Edifix therefore reports these changes to the user as a *probable* retraction (Fig. 2). Edifix gives a similar warning for an updated title indicating a retraction on PubMed, but again, only as a secondary check if there is no PubMed metadata indicating a retraction. We see updated titles with no accompanying metadata fairly often on Crossref, but so far never on PubMed.

Uppala et al. (2022) report that while they detected 14,745 retracted articles by querying Crossref for titles that included an indication of retraction, the RW database contained more than 39,000 retractions at the time of their analysis (as of August 2023, the total is over 44,000). That said, the RW database makes no distinction as to how a retraction may be indicated in Crossref/Crossmark metadata, and Uppala et al. do not indicate how many retractions could be identified with Crossmark metadata.

Retraction detection is more robust when references are validated against RW as well as Crossref and PubMed. To more comprehensively detect retractions, therefore, the Edifix team

5. Xu YC, Liu X, Li M, et al. A Novel Mechanism of Doxorubicin Resistance and Tumorigenesis Mediated by MicroRNA-501-5p-Suppressed BLID. *Mol Ther Nucleic Acids*. 2018;12:578-590. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.omtn.2018.06.011> PMID:30195794

CrossMark reports a retraction (or similarly important issue). The CrossMark type is "retraction". Additional information can be found at <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.omtn.2018.06.011>. (Ref. 5 "Xu, Liu, Li, et al, 2018")

PubMed reports that this reference was retracted in "Mol Ther Nucleic Acids. 2022 Nov 09;30:378". (Ref. 5 "Xu, Liu, Li, et al, 2018")

FIGURE 1 Edifix warning for an article listed as retracted by both PubMed and Crossref.

[3] Y. Liu, "Field weed recognition algorithm based on machine learning," *J. Electron. Imaging*, vol. 31, no. 5, p. 051413, May 2022. <https://doi.org/10.1117/1.JEI.31.5.051413>.

The title of this item indexed at CrossRef starts with "(Retracted)", indicating that this item has probably been retracted. (Ref. 3 "Liu, 2022")

FIGURE 2 Edifix warning for an article with an updated article title deposited to Crossref, but no Crossmark metadata indicating a retraction. The updated title on the publisher's website is '(Retracted) Field weed recognition algorithm based on machine learning'.

11. Lu C, Wei J. SIRT2-KLF4 Interactions are Critical for Myeloma Survival and Migration. *Comput Intell Neurosci*. 2022;2022:7356477. <https://doi.org/10.1155/2022/7356477> PMID:35669651

FIGURE 3 Edifix warning when a retracted article matched against Crossref and PubMed is also detected in the Retraction Watch database.

Retraction Watch reports that this item was **Retracted** on January 9, 2023 because the PubMed ID and DOI in the reference match the Retraction Watch database. Retraction Watch gives the reason as: "+Fake Peer Review;+Investigation by Journal/Publisher;". For more information, please see: <https://retractionwatch.com/2022/09/28/exclusive-hindawi-and-wiley-to-retract-over-500-papers-linked-to-peer-review-rings/>. (Ref. 11 "Lu, Wei, 2022")

PubMed reports that this reference was retracted in "*Comput Intell Neurosci*. 2023 Jan 9;2023:9821928". (Ref. 11 "Lu, Wei, 2022")



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Structural and functional brain differences in key opinion journal leaders

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FIGURE 4 Article attributed to Smith et al. (2018), published by Cabells-listed predatory publisher MedDocs Publishers. No longer shown on the journal's website, it lists among its authors fictional TV psychiatrists Frasier Crane (*Cheers*, *Frasier*), Alfred Bellow (*I Dream of Jeannie*), Marvin Monroe (*The Simpsons*), and Katrina Cornwell (*Star Trek: Discovery*), with affiliations including the non-existent Faber University (based on *Animal House*'s Faber College?) and Orbison University (a tribute to Roy Orbison?).

licensed the RW database and incorporated it into Edifix. When Edifix successfully matches a reference to one or more article identifiers, it will look up the identifier(s) in the RW database and, if a match is made, will add a warning, as shown in Fig. 3. In this case, the warning indicates a match on both the PubMed ID and the DOI, provides the date of the retraction and the reason(s) for the retraction from the RW database, and—if available—adds one or more links to additional information about the retraction.

What editors do with retraction warnings, of course, is up to them. In some cases, despite warnings to an editorial office that a retracted article was cited, a submitted article has been published with the retracted article still in the bibliography and no acknowledgement of the retraction, either at the point of citation or in the bibliography.

CITATIONS TO MATERIAL FROM PREDATORY PUBLISHERS

Predatory, fraudulent, or unscrupulous journal publishing practices have been a topic of conversation among scholarly communications stakeholders for many years and the subject of

scholarly research (Shamseer, 2021; West & Bergstrom, 2021)—ironically including a study that has now been retracted (Macháček & Srholec, 2022).

This can be funny when executed as parody (see Fig. 4), but not when it happens to you. No one wants to submit their research unwittingly to a predatory, illegitimate, or ethically questionable journal, or to discover after their work is published that some of their cited sources may be unreliable.

The retraction of Macháček & Srholec's 2022 study highlights how difficult it is to identify disreputable journals objectively. Beall's List was an attempt to do so, but was dogged by accusations of bias and other criticisms that ultimately led to its closure (George, 2023). More recently, Cabells Predatory Reports has set out to look more objectively and transparently at the deceptive practices that threaten to undermine quality research (Cabells Scholarly Analytics, 2023). Extensively researched and documented based on 60+ behavioural indicators, this database of over 15,000 publications is now the go-to source for information on journals that engage in predatory, deceptive, and unethical publishing practices. The detailed reports provided for each journal allow authors and publishers to make informed decisions about sources in reference lists.

Accurately identifying these journals in reference lists is tricky for editors, both because manuscripts may use abbreviated

or non-standard journal names and because predatory publishers often deliberately choose titles that resemble those of reputable journals. As with retractions, Edifix maximizes the possibility of catching journals included on the Cabells list, regardless of how they are formatted in reference lists (Fig. 5).

DETECTING FAKE REFERENCES GENERATED BY ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

2023 saw the explosion into our professional lives of ChatGPT and other LLMs, which have been rapidly and widely adopted in educational and research writing settings. Much has already been written about the potential benefits and pitfalls of using LLMs in scholarly publishing, including at least 15 posts through August 2023 on the *Scholarly Kitchen* blog alone (e.g., Esposito, 2023; Kendrick, 2023; Zhou, 2023).

The rapid embrace of LLMs has brought with it a new flavour of potential reference manipulation: fake references.

We asked ChatGPT what it is good at, and among its strengths it listed language generation: 'ChatGPT is adept at generating coherent and contextually relevant text. It can assist with writing tasks, creative writing, brainstorming ideas, or even generating code snippets, recipes, or stories'. But it also offered this caveat: 'It may occasionally provide incorrect or nonsensical answers, and its responses are generated based on patterns in its training data rather than true understanding'.

Those last words are particularly relevant to this discussion: LLMs do not have a true understanding of the questions they are asked. One type of 'nonsensical answer' especially relevant to us results from ChatGPT's current inability to generate relevant and accurate citations.

Kendrick (2023) highlighted this failure just 2 months after the public launch of ChatGPT. When he asked ChatGPT to provide a reference list for a piece it had written on racism and whiteness in academic libraries, the resulting list of 29 references revealed several significant problems.

First, half the references were from just two journals, and typically these entries were incomplete, generally lacking volume and/or issue numbers. Partly this reflects the limitations of the dataset used to train the model. Second, more worryingly, ChatGPT did not always admit to not knowing the answer. Of the 29 references it provided, only one was accurate; some contained elements of genuine references but with parts transposed, and others were completely fake.

5. Gonzalez-Aguirre AJ, Lin O, Cho C, Lesokhin AM, Maybody M. Transjugular Liver Biopsy in a Multiple Myeloma Patient with Hepatomegaly, Portal Hypertension and "Miliary" Liver Lesions: A Case Report. *J Gastrointest Dig Syst*. 2016;6(1):390. <https://doi.org/10.4172/2161-069X.1000390> PMID:28775913

Edifix found the journal title "Journal of Gastrointestinal & Digestive System" in the Cabells Predatory Reports database (Reference 5 "Gonzalez-Aguirre et al, 2016"). For full details on reported violations, see <https://www2.cabells.com/inera/predatory/QB9174I>.

In a July 2023 RW post, Joelving (2023a) highlighted a now-withdrawn preprint offering an extreme example of the references-invented-by-LLM phenomenon. The problems were first identified when Henrik Enghoff, a millipede researcher at the Natural History Museum of Denmark, received an email notifying him that one of his publications was mentioned in a new manuscript. On examining the bibliography, he found his name in several entries, all of them fake; the submitting author ultimately admitted they had been invented by ChatGPT.

We scraped the Mawcha et al. (2023) reference list from the PDF (now available at <https://retractionwatch.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/07/Mawcha-et-al-2023.pdf>) and processed it in Edifix. Our analysis suggests that the results offer (at least) three clues to detect potentially artificial intelligence (AI)-generated references.

Low overall link rate

The first clue that a reference list may not be what it seems is a low overall rate of linking on Crossref and PubMed.

There are some obvious caveats:

- Some reference types (e.g., web pages, grey literature) will not be indexed by either service.
- Book references are less likely to link to Crossref and very unlikely to link to PubMed.
- Non-STEM content is much less likely to link to PubMed, whereas Crossref has excellent coverage of STEM content and very good coverage of social sciences and humanities content.
- A DOI not registered with Crossref may be registered at any of several other agencies worldwide.

Given these limitations, however, a low link rate may indicate a fake reference list (see Table 1). An unusually low link rate for journal references is probably worth digging into, depending on the discipline; for example, we typically expect a rate of $\geq 95\%$ for journal references in life sciences, but perhaps only $\geq 80\%$ in some social science disciplines. A link rate below whatever you typically see in your content may be worth investigating, especially in an article-heavy reference list. In the case of Mawcha et al., the total link resolution rate of only 12% of all references and 15% of journal references is a significant red flag.

The Mawcha et al. (2023) reference list clearly fails this 'typical link rate' test. Of 129 references, 96 are journal articles, which usually have a very high link rate—yet only two references linked to PubMed and only 14 linked to Crossref. Of those

FIGURE 5 Edifix report for an article from a journal included in Cabells Predatory Reports.

TABLE 1 Overall results from Edifix analysis of the reference list from the now-withdrawn preprint by Mawcha et al. (2023) show an unexpectedly low link resolution rate for a life sciences article (highlighted in bold). An updated preprint (Mawcha, 2023) posted 2 months later shows better results, but still well below the expected link rate.

	Mawcha et al. (June 2023) preprints.org		Mawcha (August 2023) Research Square	
	<i>n</i>	%	<i>n</i>	%
Total references	129	100	149	100
Journal references	96	74	104	70
Book references	15	12	30	20
Other references	18	14	15	10
Linked to Crossref*	15	12	50	34
Correct DOIs	9	7	47	32
Incorrect/invalid DOIs	6	5	3	2
Author-supplied DOIs†	8	6	14	9
Correct DOIs	2	2	11	7
Incorrect/invalid DOIs	6	5	3	2
Linked to PubMed by Edifix	2	2	16	11
To cited reference	2	2	15	10
To another reference	0	0	1‡	1
Total linked references	15	12	50	34
Linked journal references	14	15	46	44

* Includes both author-supplied DOIs and DOIs retrieved by Edifix.

† Edifix checks author-supplied DOIs against the associated reference, and warns the user if the DOIs do not match.

‡ Reference 4 in Mawcha et al. (2023) matches the journal name, year, issue (but not volume), and first page of a genuine article in PubMed; Edifix warns that the remaining details do not match. Google Scholar reports that the listed authors have published one paper together, but the title given appears to be fictitious.

14, eight had DOIs already, likely provided by ChatGPT, and while most were valid Crossref DOIs, six did not match the content of the references they were associated with (see next section).

As we were drafting this article, Joelving (2023b) reported that this preprint had been submitted and withdrawn a second time, this time at Research Square (Mawcha, 2023). We repeated our testing and analysis on this new version. Of 104 journal references cited, 46 now have DOIs; of 14 DOIs supplied by the author, two are invalid and one relates to a different article. A total of 16 now link to PubMed, one corresponding to an unrelated article, as highlighted by Edifix. Although the reference list has clearly been reworked, it still fails the 'typical link rate' test.

Warnings highlighting significant differences between Crossref or PubMed metadata and the original reference

Another hallmark of AI-generated references is the presence of *chimeric* references, in which elements of one reference are combined with other elements from an unrelated one. Chimeric

references can often be detected by comparing Crossref and/or PubMed metadata with the original reference (Fig. 6).

These chimeras are not limited to two-reference hybrids. A reference cited as 'Verchot et al. (2007)' by Mawcha et al. (2023) mashes together (a) the first three authors from a 2007 paper about climate change; (b) a legitimate journal-year-volume combination, plus an invented page range; (c) the DOI from a genuine article in that volume; and (d) an apparently fictitious title:

Verchot, L.V., Van Noordwijk, M., Kandji, S.T. Variation in Soil Properties, Plant Growth and Earthworm and Termite Abundance between Two Toposequences on Alfisols in Western Kenya. *Soil Biol. Biochem.* 2007, 39, 1578-1588.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.soilbio.2007.01.015>.

The reference list in Mawcha et al. (2023) included several other chimeras. Reviewing the Edifix warnings clearly indicated *significant* concerns warranting further investigation.

Invalid author-supplied DOIs can also indicate potentially fake references. Checking that DOIs are registered with a DOI registration agency and, if they are registered with Crossref,

45. Fan W, Gao X, Ma X. Chemical Constituents and Biological Activities of Diplopodin, a Bioactive Compound from Millipedes. *Molecules*. 2019;24:543. <https://doi.org/10.3390/molecules24030543>

Edifix has not updated this reference because the article title in Crossref significantly differs from the author's original. The Crossref reference is Wang R, Zhang J, Wang S, et al. *The Cardiotoxicity Induced by Arsenic Trioxide is Alleviated by Salvianolic Acid A via Maintaining Calcium Homeostasis and Inhibiting Endoplasmic Reticulum Stress*. *Molecules*. 2019;24(3):543. (Ref. 45 "Fan, Gao, Ma, 2019")
The reference title appears to be set in title case rather than sentence case. (Ref. 45 "Fan, Gao, Ma, 2019")
Reference has only first page number. Please provide the last page number if article is longer than one page. (Ref. 45 "Fan, Gao, Ma, 2019")

FIGURE 6 Chimeric reference from Mawcha et al. (2023). The journal title, volume and page information, and DOI of a genuine OA article have been combined with an author list and article title that return no matches on a Google search.

59. De Oliveira, L.F., Souza-Filho, M.F., de Araujo, M. Soil Organic Matter Influences on Edaphic Millipede Communities in a Brazilian Tropical Dry Forest. *J. Arid Environ.* 2019, 64, 80–86, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jaridenv.2019.0>.

Crossref does not recognize the DOI "10.1016/j.jaridenv.2019.0", and reports it is not registered at any other registration agency. Please check the accuracy of the DOI. (Ref. 59 "De Oliveira, Souza-Filho, de Araujo, 2019")

FIGURE 7 Reference from Mawcha et al. (2023) with an invalid DOI, as reported by Edifix. In this case, a Google search found that the reference is also fake, although the presence of a DOI might lead some readers to believe it is legitimate.

comparing the registered metadata with the original reference content, can reveal fake references (Fig. 7).

An excessive number of 'unknown' references

The reference parsing technology behind Edifix can handle references formatted to a range of editorial styles, but certain anomalies will prevent Edifix from parsing a journal reference, including the absence of key pieces of information.

For example, a recent Edifix job showed only six of 20 references successfully parsed, and closer inspection revealed that the majority of the unparsed references were journal references with no journal title. This is exactly the kind of mistake that ChatGPT is known to make—missing key pieces of information from the reference because it does not understand what the different elements mean.

A parse rate below 50% from Edifix, or manually detecting that key elements are missing from references, is therefore another indication that further analysis is warranted.

CONCLUSIONS

In isolation, any of the individual issues discussed here might not raise a red flag. In combination, however, they should prompt a closer look. Just as plagiarism-detection software gives the user an indicator of possible plagiarism, rather than a definitive answer

to the question *Was this article plagiarised?*, analysing the bibliography can provide indications that a closer look is needed, rather than a definitive answer to the question *Are these references legitimate?*

We have shown here that analysis of the bibliography can surface clues that an article may need further investigation of potential research integrity issues. While these tests can be conducted manually, scaling them up for use in a production environment requires automated methods such as those described here.

As with other indicators, such as detection of possible image manipulation, data fabrication, or plagiarism, the responsibility then rests with the publisher to investigate whether there are genuine grounds for concern, and to take appropriate action.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Contributions: BR conceived this study and conducted some initial analysis. RD conducted the formal analysis and wrote the initial draft. BR and SIH reviewed and edited the initial draft.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

At the time of writing, all authors were employed by Wiley Partner Solutions. All authors were (R.D., B.R.) or had previously been (S.I.H.) involved in developing or testing Edifix, described in this article, and/or the eXtyle reference processing tools on which Edifix is based.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Edifix results for the references analysed in this study are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

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